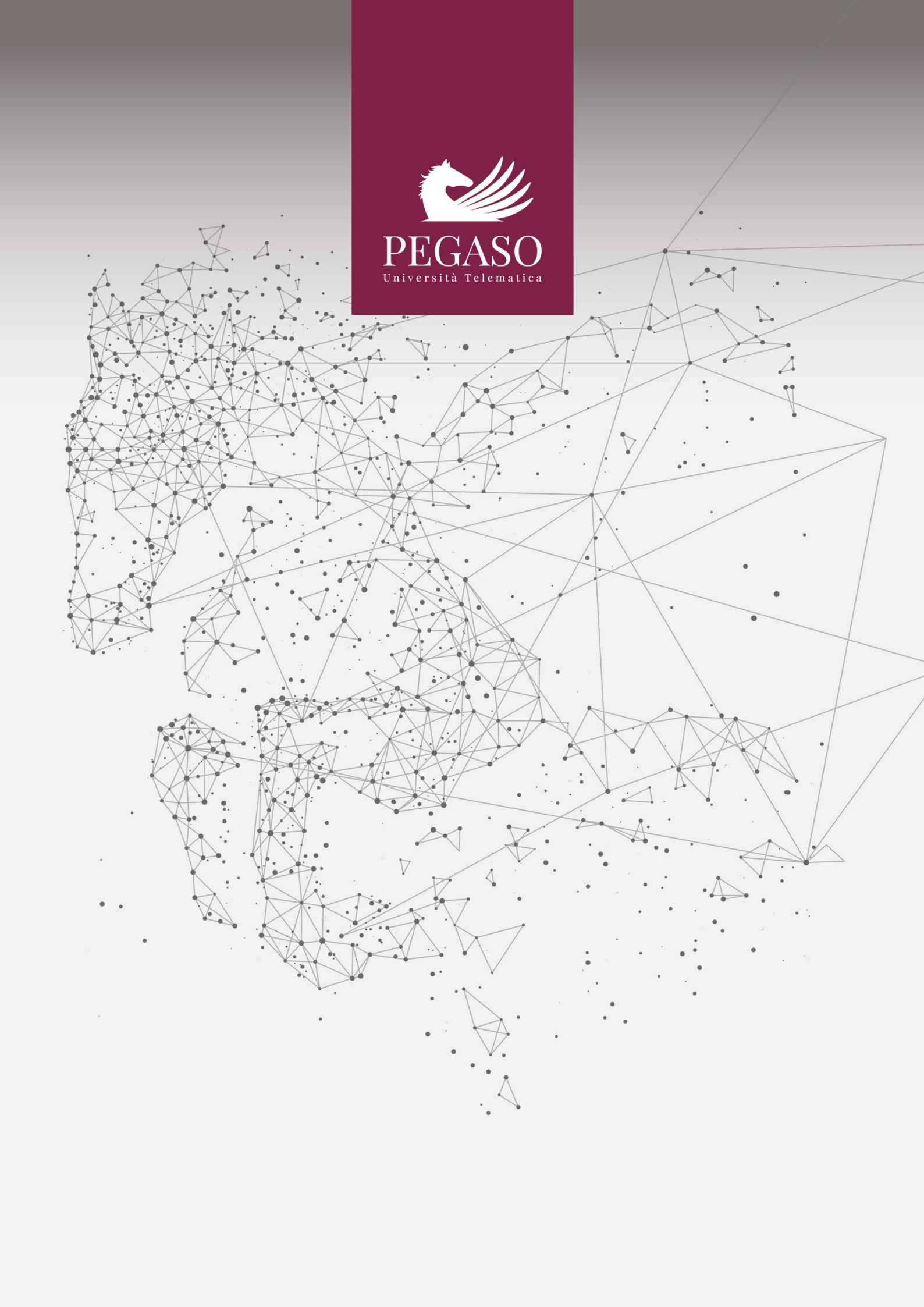

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1. Introduction to Modal Verbs and Modal Phrases

A modal is a type of auxiliary verb (used together with the infinitive form of a main verb) that is used to express: ability, possibility, permission or obligation. Modal phrases (sometimes called semi-modals) are used to express the same ideas as proper modals, but these modal phrases are a combination of other non-modal auxiliary verbs and the preposition *to* + infinitive. Examples of modal verbs and modal phrases in English are: *can/could/be able to* + infinitive*; may/might* + infinitive*; should/ought to/be supposed to* + infinitive*, must/have to* + infinitive*, will/would* + infinitive, *need to* + infinitive.

All modal verbs have only one form for all subjects (I, you, he/ she/ it, etc.) and to make negatives we simple add **not** to the modal verb and in questions we use simple inversion of the subject and modal. Modal verbs referring to the present or future are followed by the basic infinitive form of another non-modal main verb.

You can leave your bag here.

She can come if she wants to.

Negative:

You mustn't leave your bag here. (***modal + not + infinitive***)

Interrogative:

Should I leave my bag here? (***modal + subject + infinitive***)

The formation of modal phrases (semi-modals) depends on the non-modal auxiliary verb used:

The same rules for the verb BE as an auxiliary apply to: ***be able to + infinitive, be supposed to + infinitive*** **and** ***be allowed to + infinitve***.

I wasn't supposed to hear what he said but he was talking so loudly with the door to his office open.

Are you able to see the traffic sign without your glasses?

The same rules for all main verbs (using do/does/did/will to create negatives and questions in past, present or future) apply to: ***have to + infinitive*** **and** ***need to + infinitive***

I didn't have to study so hard but I wanted to impress the teacher.

You won't need to come with me. I'm ok on my own.

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Do you have to work late today?

Will you need to buy more coffee after we have guests over in the morning?

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2. Possibility, Ability and Deduction

Possibility

We use the modal verbs **can** or **could** for theoretical possibility.

Can there be life on Mars?

Can that be Peter over there?

The weather could be better tomorrow. (= it's possible)

We use the modal verbs **may, might, could** to talk about likelihood in the present or future.

He may be in a meeting.

She might/could be here already.

Ability

We use the modal verbs **can/could** to express general ability and typical behavior of people or things.

Temperatures can rise to over 30°C in the summer.

Employers can be unwilling to employ people over fifty.

My father could be very generous. (= past)

We use **can/be able to** for present and future ability.

I can understand French but I can't speak it very well.

Will your parents be able to help you?

I like being able to cook my own meals.

We use the modal verb **can** for the future where there is a sense of opportunity.

I can come tomorrow if you like.

You can practice your French when you go to Paris.

We use the modal verbs **could/couldn't** and the modal phrase **was able to** to talk about general past ability.

I could swim before I could walk.

I was able to talk when I was eighteen months.

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Andrew's father couldn't get a job.

We use the modal phrase **was/wasn't able to** to talk about past ability in a specific past situation.

Fortunately, he was able to swim to the shore.

Other expressions for ability:

Do you know how to type? (know how + to + infinitive)

He succeeded in becoming a professional footballer at eighteen. (succeed in + gerund)

We managed to find our way home. (manage to + infinitive, which suggests difficulty)

Certainty of Deduction

We use the modal verb **must** + infinitive to say that we are sure about something in the present.

You must be pleased with your exam results. (= present)

We use the modal verb **can't** in negative sentences to indicate that we are sure that something is not true in the present. Note: We do not use mustn't.

That can't be Keira Knightley. She's too old.

He can’t be working today. He’s left his computer here on his desk.[1]

We use the modal verbs **might/may/could** + infinitive to say that we are not sure about something in the present. We think something is possibly true, but we are not certain.

She’s not here yet. She might still be at work.

He’s not answering his phone. He could be in class.

We regret to inform you that some services may be delayed due to stormy weather.

[1] J. Bell and A. Thomas, *Gold First Coursebook New Edition*, Essex, Pearson Education Limited, 2014 (170)

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3. Obligation, Necessity, Prohibition and Permission

Obligation, Necessity, Prohibition

We use the modal verbs **must/mustn't** and the modal phrase **(not) allowed to** to talk about present and future obligations/prohibitions imposed by the speaker, often on him/herself.

Payment must be made in cash.

I must get some new shoes.

You must read that book, it's excellent! (= recommendation)

Must I really go now? (= appeal)

You mustn't park here. (= prohibition)

You mustn't eat so much. (= strong advice)

You aren't allowed to wear trainers to school.

We use the modal phrase **have to** (and its variant **have got to**) to talk about present and future obligations that are imposed by someone other than the speaker.

Be careful: **have got to** is more common in British than American English.

I have (got) to take my holiday in February.

Have we got to pay to go in?

We use the modal phrase **had to** to talk about past and reported obligations of all kinds.

They told us we had to leave our bags in the cloakroom.

We had to stand up when the teacher came in.

I knew we had to make a decision.[2]

Important Distinctions to Highlight between *Must* and *Have to*:

The modal verb **must** and the modal phrase **have to** have very similar meanings. We normally prefer to use **have to** in spoken English to talk about obligation. In formal, written English, we prefer to use **must**.

[2] J. Bell and A. Thomas, *Gold First Coursebook New Edition*, Essex, Pearson Education Limited, 2014 (170)

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But the negative forms of **mustn't** and **don't have to** have very different meanings. **Mustn't** expresses a rule - we use **mustn't** to say 'don't do this'. **Don't have to** doesn't express a rule - we use **don't have to** to say 'it's not necessary to do this'.

Customers must not enter the kitchen. (= Don't do this!)

The restaurant is huge. You don't have to book a table. (=It is not necessary.)

We also use the modal phrase **need to** to talk about obligation and necessity.

Do we need to type our work?

You need to book tickets in advance.

Lack of Obligation or Necessity

We use the modal phrases **don't need to**, **don't have to** to talk about a lack of obligation in the present or future.

You don't need to meet me at the station.

We don't have to wait. We can go straight in.

We use the modal phrase **didn't need to** to say that something wasn't necessary without saying whether the person did it or not.

You didn't need to bring any extra money. She didn't need to cook dinner for all of us!

Permission

To give permission, we use the modal verb **can**.

You can pay for your drinks when you leave.

To say somebody doesn't have permission, we use the modal verb **can't (**or **cannot**).

You can't sit in this part of the restaurant. (or You cannot sit.)

We also use the modal phrases **allowed to** and **not allowed to** to talk about permission.

Are we allowed to take our food outside?

You're not allowed to park there.[3]

[3] H. Stephenson, J. Hughes, P. Dummett, *Life Intermediate Student Book Second Edition*, Hampshire, National Geographic Learning, 2019 (164)

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4. Advice

For giving advice or recommendations we use the modal verb **should** and the modal phrases **ought to** and **be supposed to**.

We use **ought to** and **should** to talk about obligations and duties in the future, present, or to give advice.

You ought to/should speak English in class.

Shouldn't we tell someone about the accident?

We can use **be supposed to** when saying what someone should or should not do according to rules or regulations.

You're not supposed to park here.

I'm supposed to call my mum when we leave the party.

Other phrases for advice include:

You could get the next flight. (could)

If I were you, 'd phone him. (would)

I'd advise you not to park there. (would advise)[4]

Exercises

Choose the best alternative in the following sentences.

1. He ***might/must*** be here somewhere because he promised to meet me.
2. The boat for New York ***can't/could*** be leaving already. It's too early.
3. Surely they ***can't be playing/must be playing*** football. It's snowing![5]

Choose the correct modal verb.

4. If you are arrested you ***don't have to / are not*** *allowed to* answer all the police's questions.
5. Witnesses ***mustn't / don't have to*** tell lies in court.
6. We ***must / had to*** stay in our prison cells for up to twenty-three hours per day. It was awful.
7. We ***must / have to*** carry our identity cards at all times.[6]

[4] J. Bell and A. Thomas, *Gold First Coursebook New Edition*, Essex, Pearson Education Limited, 2014 (170)
[5] J. Bell and A. Thomas, *Gold First Coursebook New Edition*, Essex, Pearson Education Limited, 2014 (70)
[6] J. Bell and A. Thomas, *Gold First Coursebook New Edition*, Essex, Pearson Education Limited, 2014 (122)

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Choose the correct verb form to complete the sentences. Both may be possible.

8. After we'd tried everything, we ***could / were able to*** get the computer to work at last.

9. When we lived on the coast we ***could / were able to*** swim every day in the summer.

10. She must ***can / be able to*** leave earlier than that.

11. I hope ***can / to be able to*** finish this today.[7]

Read the signs. Complete the sentences with the correct modal form. Write all the possible answers.

TICKETS NEEDED BEFORE ENTRY

12. You _____buy a ticket before you enter.

TABLETS AND PHONES ALLOWED ON THIS FLIGHT

13. You _____ switch off your tablets or phones on this flight.

NO PARKING

14. You _____park here.

THIS FILM IS NOT RECOMMENDED FOR CHILDREN

15. Children _____ see this film.

EXAM IN PROGRESS: BE QUIET!

16. You _____ speak quietly.

SERVICE INCLUDED: TIP NOT NECESSARY

17. You _____ leave a tip in this restaurant.

NO ENTRY EXCEPT FOR CYCLISTS

18. You _____ ride your bicycle here.

Complete the text with modal verbs and the verb in brackets. Use affirmative and negative forms of the modal verbs.

School dinners are very popular in the UK. Most children 19. _____(pay) for school dinners, but they don't cost a lot. However, poorer families 20._____(pay) - the school dinners are free.

There are strict rules about school dinners. For example, every meal 21._____(include) meat or fish, fruit and vegetables and bread, potatoes and other cereals. Another rule is that school canteens 22._____(sell) food and drinks with a lot of sugar and salt.

[7] J. Bell and A. Thomas, *Gold First Coursebook New Edition*, Essex, Pearson Education Limited, 2014 (132)

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Children 23. _____(eat) school dinners if they don't want to. They 24._____(bring) a 'packed lunch' from home. There are many recommendations for the types of food to give children in their packed lunches. For example, children 25. _____(eat) fruit every day and they 26._____(have) junk food like crisps and chocolate.[8]

27. Translate the following text into Italian.

Authentic Pizza Napoletana is part of an elite group of European Union-certified food and drink products - like Scottish Farmed Salmon, Spanish Melon from La Mancha and English Blue Stilton cheese. In order to qualify for this list, these food products had to pass strict tests. To be labeled “Guaranteed”, the pizza mustn't be over 35 centimeters in diameter and the crust mustn't be more than two centimeters thick. The ingredients have to include type 00 flour and up to 100 grams of San Marzano tomatoes applied in a spiral. And, of course, the cheese has to be fresh 'Mozzarella di Bufala. It can’t be very easy to find these ingredients outside of Italy but a holiday to that country could be more than worth the time and expense. You should try an authentic Pizza Napoletana at least once, and see if you can taste the difference.[9]

Exercise answer key

1. Must be
2. Can’t be
3. Can’t be playing
4. Don’t have to
5. Mustn’t
6. Had to
7. Have to
8. Were able to
9. Could swim
10. Be able to
11. To be able to
12. Have to/must/need to
13. Don’t have to
14. Can’t/mustn’t/aren’t allowed to

[8] H. Stephenson, J. Hughes, P. Dummett, *Life Intermediate Student Book Second Edition*, Hampshire, National Geographic Learning, 2019 (165)
[9] H. Stephenson, J. Hughes, P. Dummett, *Life Intermediate Student Book Second Edition*, Hampshire, National Geographic Learning, 2019 (58)

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15. Shouldn’t/ought not to
16. Must/have to
17. Don’t need to/don’t have to
18. Can/are allowed to/could
19. Have to pay
20. Don’t need to pay/don’t have to pay
21. Must include/has to include
22. Mustn’t sell
23. Don’t have to eat/don’t need to eat
24. Can bring/are allowed to bring/could bring
25. Should eat/ought to eat
26. Shouldn’t have/ought not to have
27. L'Autentica Pizza Napoletana fa parte di un'élite di prodotti alimentari e di bevande certificati dall'Unione Europea, come il salmone d'allevamento scozzese, il melone spagnolo de La Mancia e il formaggio inglese Blue Stilton. Per entrare a far parte di questo elenco, questi prodotti alimentari hanno dovuto superare test rigorosi. Per essere etichettata come “Garantita”, la pizza non deve superare i 35 centimetri di diametro e la crosta non deve essere spessa più di due centimetri. Gli ingredienti devono includere farina di tipo 00 e fino a 100 grammi di pomodori San Marzano applicati a spirale. E, naturalmente, il formaggio deve essere “Mozzarella di Bufala” fresca. Non è molto facile trovare questi ingredienti al di fuori dell'Italia, ma una vacanza in questo Paese potrebbe più che meritare il tempo e le spese che si devono affrontare.

Bisognerebbe provare almeno una volta un'autentica Pizza Napoletana e vedere se si riesce a sentire la differenza.

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